

Future Forms with Nuance

C1 · Renan the Teacher — English Language Academy

1. BRIEF EXPLANATION

Beyond "will" and "going to," C1 English uses more nuanced future structures, especially for narrative writing and describing plans that existed at a particular past moment.

- a) Future-in-the-past — used to talk about something that was going to happen (or was planned/expected to happen) viewed from a point in the past. This is essential for storytelling.
- - was/were going to + bare infinitive: She was going to call me, but she forgot.
- - would + bare infinitive: He didn't know it yet, but this decision would change his life forever.
- - was/were about to + bare infinitive: I was about to leave when the phone rang.
- - was/were to + bare infinitive (formal/literary, often for events later described as fated or officially scheduled): They were to meet again only years later.
- b) Complex future reference in narratives — combining future-in-the-past with other tenses to build a timeline within a story, often mixing:
 - - past simple for the main narrative events,
 - - past continuous for background,
 - - future-in-the-past for what was still to come,
 - - past perfect for what had already happened before the story's "now."

By the time she boarded the plane, she had already decided she wasn't coming back. She was going to start a completely new life.

- c) Nuance differences:
 - - "was going to" often implies the plan changed or didn't happen (unfulfilled).
 - - "would" (future-in-the-past) is common in narration for planned or inevitable future events, often without any sense of failure.
 - - "was about to" emphasizes something on the very brink of happening, often interrupted.

2. EXAMPLES

1. She was going to study abroad, but the scholarship fell through.
2. Little did he know that this stranger would become his best friend.
3. I was about to knock when the door swung open.
4. The treaty, signed in 1919, was to shape the next century of European politics.
5. He promised he would call as soon as he landed.
6. We were going to have a picnic, but it started raining.
7. She had no idea that the interview would change her career forever.
8. Just as I was about to give up, I found the missing file.

- 9. The young officer, then unknown, was later to become a national hero.
- 10. He said he would finish the project by Friday.
- 11. They were going to sell the house, but they changed their minds at the last moment.
- 12. As she packed her bags, she realized she was about to leave her old life behind.

3. COMMON MISTAKES

- 1. Incorrect: She was going to called me later that day.

Correct: She was going to call me later that day.

Why: "Was going to" is always followed by the bare infinitive, not the past form.

- 2. Incorrect: He didn't know that this decision will change everything.

Correct: He didn't know that this decision would change everything.

Why: Inside a past narrative, future-in-the-past requires "would," not "will."

- 3. Incorrect: I was about to leaving when she called.

Correct: I was about to leave when she called.

Why: "Was about to" takes the bare infinitive, not the gerund.

- 4. Incorrect: They was going to travel next month.

Correct: They were going to travel next month.

Why: Subject-verb agreement — "they" needs "were," not "was."

- 5. Incorrect: The treaty was signing to shape the future.

Correct: The treaty was to shape the future.

Why: "Was/were to + infinitive" (formal, meaning "was destined/scheduled to") doesn't take a gerund.

4. EXERCISES

- A. Gap-fill (was/were going to, would, was/were about to, was/were to)
- 1. He ____ (leave) the room when the lights suddenly went out.
- 2. She had no idea that this trip ____ (change) her outlook on life.
- 3. We ____ (visit) the museum, but it was closed for renovation.
- 4. The young painter, still unknown at the time, ____ (become) world-famous within a decade.
- 5. I ____ (call) you, but my phone died before I could.
- 6. He promised that he ____ (write) every week while he was away.
- 7. Just as she ____ (open) the letter, the phone rang.
- 8. They ____ (get married) that summer, but the wedding was postponed.
- B. Rewrite / Transformation (rewrite the underlined idea using future-in-

the-past)

- 1. His plan was to open a restaurant, but he never did. (use "was going to")
- 2. At the time, nobody knew that the invention would change the world. (rewrite with "would," keeping the meaning)
- 3. I was on the verge of leaving when I heard the news. (rewrite with "was about to")
- 4. It was later revealed that the two rivals would become close friends. (rewrite with "were to")
- 5. She planned to quit her job that year, but she got a promotion instead. (use "was going to")
- 6. We were on the point of signing the contract when the deal collapsed. (rewrite with "were about to")
- C. Error Correction
- 1. She was going to visited her grandmother, but it snowed all week.
- 2. He didn't realize that this mistake will cost him his job.
- 3. I were about to leave when the taxi arrived.
- 4. The general, then a young soldier, was to becoming a national symbol.
- 5. They was going to cancel the trip.
- 6. As I was about to signing the form, I noticed the error.
- D. Guided Production
- 1. Write one sentence using "was/were going to" about a plan that didn't happen.
- 2. Write one sentence using "would" as future-in-the-past inside a short narrative.
- 3. Write one sentence using "was/were about to" describing an interrupted moment.
- 4. Write two connected sentences telling a short story that mixes past simple, past perfect and future-in-the-past.

5. ANSWER KEY

- A. Gap-fill
- 1. was about to leave
- 2. would change
- 3. were going to visit
- 4. would become
- 5. was going to call
- 6. would write
- 7. was about to open
- 8. were going to get married
- B. Rewrite / Transformation
- 1. He was going to open a restaurant, but he never did.
- 2. At the time, nobody knew that the invention would change the world.
- 3. I was about to leave when I heard the news.
- 4. It was later revealed that the two rivals were to become close friends.
- 5. She was going to quit her job that year, but she got a promotion instead.
- 6. We were about to sign the contract when the deal collapsed.
- C. Error Correction
- 1. She was going to visit her grandmother, but it snowed all week.
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- 6. As I was about to sign the form, I noticed the error.
- D. Guided Production (sample answers)
- 1. We were going to spend the summer in Portugal, but our plans changed after the job offer.
- 2. She had no idea, as she signed the lease, that this apartment would become her home for the next ten years.
- 3. I was about to fall asleep when I heard a strange noise downstairs.
- 4. By the time the sun rose, she had already packed her bags. She was going to start a new chapter, far from everything she had ever known.

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